

When Fisher–Rao Geometry Helps Representation Learning: Robust Affinity Matching Under False Neighbors

Maruano T. Bottoni
Independent Research Prototype
`fisher-rao-ml`

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Abstract

The Kullback–Leibler (KL) divergence is the dominant primitive for comparing probability distributions in representation-learning objectives such as t-SNE. KL is asymmetric and unbounded: these properties are useful when the target affinity distribution is clean, but can become liabilities when the target contains spurious high-confidence neighbors. We test the Fisher–Rao geodesic distance as a bounded, symmetric alternative on the categorical simplex. The main positive result is a structured affinity-corruption stress test: when the training target P is contaminated with false high-probability cross-cluster edges, Fisher–Rao preserves clean neighborhoods and assigns substantially less embedding mass to the corrupted pairs than KL. At false-edge mass 0.2, Fisher–Rao improves trustworthiness by +0.068, clean-neighborhood recall by +0.100, and reduces corrupted-edge preservation by −0.149. We also include a standard multi-seed t-SNE benchmark as a boundary condition: under clean or feature-noised targets, KL remains better for cluster separation and Fisher–Rao is usually a tie. A compact VAE study is reported as a secondary check and does not show a reliable advantage. The resulting claim is narrow but actionable: Fisher–Rao is not a universal KL replacement, but its bounded geometry is useful for robust affinity matching when the affinity graph itself is contaminated.

1 Introduction

t-SNE [8] is one of the most widely used nonlinear dimensionality reduction methods. Its success rests in part on a specific design choice: the low- and high-dimensional neighborhood probability distributions are compared with the Kullback–Leibler divergence [3]. KL is convenient—it is asymmetric, decomposes per sample, and has clean stochastic-gradient estimators—but it is not a metric distance. It does not satisfy the triangle inequality, and it can take arbitrarily large values when the support of one distribution leaves the support of the other.

Information geometry [1, 5, 7] suggests a more geometric primitive. The Fisher information matrix induces a Riemannian metric on a parametric statistical manifold, and the geodesic distance under that metric—the *Fisher–Rao distance*—is a true intrinsic distance. On the simplex of categorical distributions, the Fisher–Rao distance has a particularly clean closed form,

$$d_{\text{FR}}(p, q) = 2 \arccos\left(\sum_i \sqrt{p_i q_i}\right), \quad (1)$$

and is bounded by π [5]. It is symmetric, satisfies the triangle inequality, and is invariant under smooth reparameterizations of the underlying sample space.

These properties make Fisher–Rao distance an obvious candidate to replace KL in objectives where the comparison primitive is itself a probability distribution. In particular, the t-SNE loss

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{KL}}(Y) = \text{KL}(P \parallel Q(Y)) \quad (2)$$

can be turned into

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{FR}}(Y) = d_{\text{FR}}(P, Q(Y))^2, \quad (3)$$

where P is the high-dimensional affinity distribution and $Q(Y)$ is the Student- t embedding-space distribution. Both are normalized over pair indices.

The empirical-evaluation gap. Although the geometric motivation for Fisher–Rao in t-SNE is folklore in the information-geometry community [5, 6], we are unaware of any rigorous, multi-seed, multi-dataset evaluation of this specific replacement. Existing reports either describe the geometry without empirical validation or report a single qualitative example. Modern empirical ML expects paired comparisons, multiple seeds, and explicit significance tests [2, 10]. We provide them.

Contributions.

1. A differentiable PyTorch implementation of the Fisher–Rao distance for categorical distributions, suitable for use as a drop-in replacement for KL in affinity-matching objectives.
2. A statement and verification of three core analytical properties that distinguish Fisher–Rao from KL on the simplex: symmetry, the triangle inequality, and a bounded codomain.
3. A targeted structured-affinity stress test showing that Fisher–Rao can help when the target affinity distribution contains sparse false-neighbor probability mass, because its bounded simplex geometry reduces overfitting to corrupted high-confidence edges.
4. A paired benchmark of KL versus Fisher–Rao squared as a t-SNE objective across three datasets, feature-noise levels, ten seeds, and objective-independent embedding metrics, establishing where the positive robustness result does *not* apply.
5. A secondary beta-tuned VAE check, reported briefly, showing that the same replacement is not yet compelling for compact diagonal-Gaussian VAEs.

Headline finding. Fisher–Rao’s value is conditional. In ordinary clean-target and feature-noise t-SNE benchmarks, KL remains the safer default. But when P itself contains false high-probability edges, KL faithfully overfits the corrupted target while Fisher–Rao resists the bad edges and better preserves the clean geometry. This gives a precise answer to “when should the geometry matter?”: when boundedness is robustness rather than underfitting.

2 Background

2.1 KL divergence

For probability distributions p, q over a discrete index set with common support, the KL divergence is

$$\text{KL}(p \parallel q) = \sum_i p_i \log \frac{p_i}{q_i}. \quad (4)$$

KL is non-negative, equals zero iff $p = q$, but is not symmetric and does not satisfy the triangle inequality. As $q_i \rightarrow 0$ with p_i fixed and positive, $\text{KL}(p \parallel q)$ diverges. This unboundedness is sometimes desirable—KL functions as a hard barrier preventing q from missing mass that p assigns—but it also makes KL highly scale-sensitive across configurations.

2.2 Fisher–Rao distance on the simplex

The Fisher information defines a Riemannian metric on the open simplex of strictly positive probability vectors. The square-root map $p \mapsto \sqrt{p}$ sends this simplex to the positive orthant of the unit sphere S_+^{n-1} , and pulls the spherical round metric back to the Fisher information metric [5]. Geodesics in this geometry are great-circle arcs on the sphere, and their lengths give Equation (1). Equivalently, d_{FR} is twice the spherical angle between $\sqrt{p}$ and $\sqrt{q}$.

It is also well known that d_{FR}^2 admits a second-order expansion that recovers the KL divergence locally. Around any interior point p , with $q = p + \delta$ and small δ ,

$$d_{\text{FR}}(p, q)^2 = 2 \text{KL}(p \parallel q) + O(\|\delta\|^3), \quad (5)$$

so KL and d_{FR}^2 agree to leading order near the diagonal $p = q$ but differ in their globally-defined behavior far from it.

2.3 Properties

Proposition 1 (Symmetry, metric, bounded codomain). *For any p, q in the open simplex,*

1. $d_{\text{FR}}(p, q) = d_{\text{FR}}(q, p)$,
2. d_{FR} is a metric and satisfies the triangle inequality,
3. $0 \leq d_{\text{FR}}(p, q) \leq \pi$, hence $0 \leq d_{\text{FR}}(p, q)^2 \leq \pi^2 \approx 9.87$.

Sketch. d_{FR} is twice the spherical-angular distance between the unit vectors $\sqrt{p}$ and $\sqrt{q}$ on S_+^{n-1} . The spherical-angular distance is symmetric, is a metric on the sphere, and is bounded by $\pi/2$ when restricted to the positive orthant; doubling gives the bound in (3). See Nielsen [5]. $\square$

Property (3) is the cleanest practical contrast with KL. KL is unbounded above on the simplex; d_{FR}^2 is bounded by π^2 . Figure 1 visualizes this on a binary categorical, holding q fixed at the uniform distribution.

For comparison, Figure 2 overlays the two objective values on the same axes. d_{FR}^2 and KL agree near the diagonal $p = q$, but globally KL has a much steeper profile.

2.4 Fisher–Rao distance for diagonal Gaussian VAE posteriors

The VAE setting is geometrically different from the categorical simplex. The encoder produces a diagonal Gaussian posterior $q_\phi(z|x) = \mathcal{N}(\mu_\phi(x), \text{diag}(\sigma_\phi^2(x)))$ and the prior is $p(z) = \mathcal{N}(0, I)$. The usual VAE regularizer is the closed-form $\text{KL}(q_\phi(z|x) \parallel p(z))$. Our Fisher–Rao replacement treats each latent coordinate as a univariate Gaussian manifold and sums squared coordinate-wise geodesic lengths. For univariate Gaussians, this geometry is hyperbolic:

$$d_{\text{FR}}(\mu, \sigma; \mu_0, \sigma_0) = \sqrt{2} \operatorname{arcosh} \left(1 + \frac{(\mu - \mu_0)^2 + 2(\sigma - \sigma_0)^2}{4\sigma\sigma_0} \right). \quad (6)$$

Unlike the categorical simplex distance, this Gaussian Fisher–Rao distance is not bounded. The VAE motivation is therefore not bounded codomain; it is the intrinsic geometry of the Gaussian family and a different coupling of posterior mean and variance deviations from the prior.

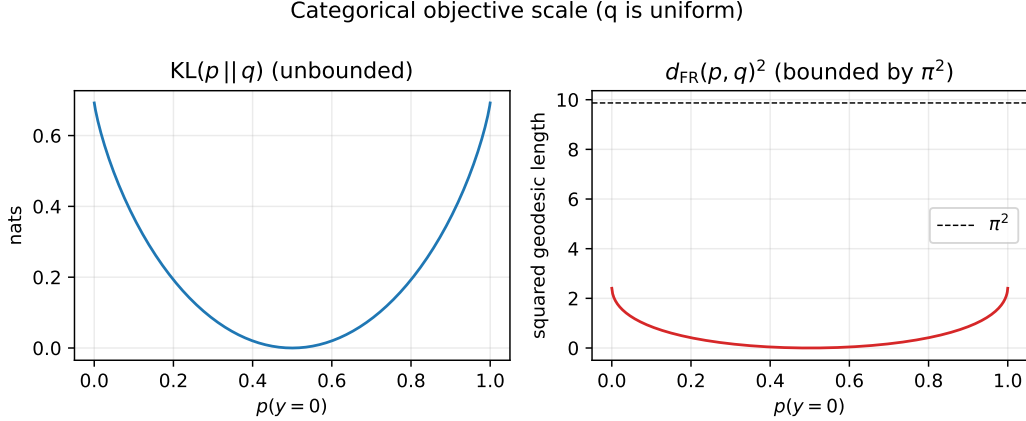


Figure 1: Categorical objective scale. With q uniform, $\text{KL}(p \parallel q)$ diverges as p approaches a simplex vertex, while $d_{\text{FR}}(p, q)^2$ is bounded by π^2 .

3 Methods

3.1 t-SNE objective with paired KL and Fisher–Rao variants

We implement t-SNE in PyTorch with explicit pairwise affinities. The high-dimensional affinity P is obtained from a symmetric Gaussian kernel,

$$P_{ij} \propto \exp(-\|x_i - x_j\|^2 / (2\sigma^2)), \quad P_{ii} = 0, \quad \sum_{ij} P_{ij} = 1, \quad (7)$$

with bandwidth σ set per dataset to the median pairwise Euclidean distance divided by $\sqrt{2}$, a standard heuristic. The low-dimensional affinity $Q(Y)$ uses a Student- t kernel as in van der Maaten and Hinton [8],

$$Q_{ij}(Y) \propto (1 + \|y_i - y_j\|^2)^{-1}, \quad Q_{ii} = 0, \quad \sum_{ij} Q_{ij} = 1. \quad (8)$$

The KL t-SNE objective is $\mathcal{L}_{\text{KL}}(Y) = \text{KL}(P \parallel Q(Y))$ and the Fisher–Rao variant is $\mathcal{L}_{\text{FR}}(Y) = d_{\text{FR}}(P, Q(Y))^2$, with both losses applied to the flattened pair distributions. Both are minimized with Adam at learning rate 0.05 for 300 steps. Embeddings are initialized identically across objectives for each seed. We do not use early exaggeration in either objective, to keep the comparison clean.

3.2 Datasets

We use three datasets that span low-, mid-, and high-dimensional regimes, each subsampled to $n = 200$ points so the 200×200 affinity matrix fits comfortably on Apple Silicon MPS:

- **Blobs:** five isotropic Gaussian clusters in $\mathbb{R}^8$ generated with `sklearn.datasets.make_blobs`, cluster standard deviation 1.6.
- **Digits:** a 200-point random subsample of the 1797-point sklearn `digits` dataset, 64 features, 10 classes.
- **MNIST:** a 200-point random subsample of MNIST [4], flattened to 784 features, 10 classes.

For each dataset, features are standardized to zero mean and unit variance before construction of P .

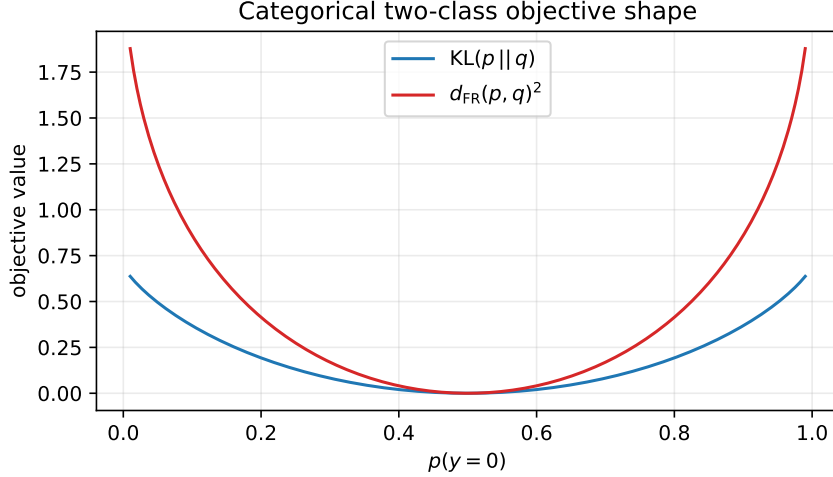


Figure 2: Two-class categorical objectives compared against a uniform target. The two curves agree to leading order near $p = q$ but differ globally: KL grows without bound while d_{FR}^2 saturates near π^2 .

3.3 Robustness corruption

We test robustness by injecting isotropic Gaussian noise into the high-dimensional features before constructing P . For a corruption level $\alpha \in \{0, 0.25, 0.5, 0.75, 1.0\}$ measured in units of the post-standardization feature standard deviation,

$$\tilde{X}_\alpha = X + \alpha \epsilon, \quad \epsilon \sim \mathcal{N}(0, I). \quad (9)$$

The embedding is optimized using $\tilde{X}_\alpha$ but evaluated against the clean labels and (for trustworthiness and neighborhood recall) against the clean X . This isolates the effect of the corruption on the affinity-building stage.

3.4 Evaluation metrics

The four embedding-quality metrics are objective-independent and standard in the neighborhood-embedding literature [9]:

- **Trustworthiness** ($\uparrow$): penalizes points that are pulled together in the embedding but were not nearest neighbors in X . Computed with $k = 10$.
- **Neighborhood recall** ($\uparrow$): fraction of X -space k -nearest neighbors recovered as Y -space k -nearest neighbors, $k = 10$.
- **Silhouette score** ($\uparrow$): mean silhouette of cluster labels in the embedding, measuring cluster separation in the embedding space.
- **kNN accuracy** ($\uparrow$): test accuracy of a 5-NN classifier on a 70/30 stratified split of the embedding, measured against the clean labels.

3.5 Statistical analysis

For each (dataset, noise) cell, the same 10 seeds are used to train both objectives. Each seed yields one paired observation $(x_i^{\text{KL}}, x_i^{\text{FR}})$ per metric. We report

- $x^{\text{KL}} \pm \text{std}$ and $x^{\text{FR}} \pm \text{std}$ across seeds,
- the paired difference $\Delta_i = x_i^{\text{FR}} - x_i^{\text{KL}}$, and
- the two-sided Wilcoxon signed-rank test [10] on Δ , which does not assume normality and handles small n .
- Cliff’s delta [2] as a non-parametric effect size, $\delta \in [-1, 1]$, with positive values meaning Fisher–Rao tends to exceed KL.

Following standard practice we mark $p < 0.05$ as significant. We do not apply Bonferroni across all 60 cells, but we report all p -values, so the reader can apply any preferred correction.

3.6 Secondary VAE protocol

We train a fully connected VAE with one hidden layer of width 400, latent dimension 8, Adam at learning rate 10^{-3} , batch size 128, and gradient clipping at norm 10. Each run uses 1024 training examples and 512 held-out examples. We evaluate two datasets whose downloads completed reproducibly in the local environment: MNIST and Fashion-MNIST. The code also supports KMNIST, but the KMNIST server timed out during the paper run; the script records this as dataset-unavailable rather than failing the analysis pipeline.

Because KL and Gaussian Fisher–Rao have different scales, beta is tuned separately. KL uses $\beta \in \{0.1, 0.3, 1.0, 3.0\}$ and Fisher–Rao uses $\beta \in \{0.03, 0.1, 0.3, 1.0\}$ over five seeds (101, 202, 303, 404, 505), producing 80 trained models. For each (dataset, regularizer, seed) we select beta using

$$\text{score} = \text{BCE/pixel} - 0.05 \text{ latent kNN},$$

so the selected model must reconstruct well without ignoring representation usefulness.

VAE metrics are objective-independent: BCE/pixel and MSE for reconstruction; latent kNN, linear-probe accuracy, and latent silhouette for representation quality; active units, posterior variance, entropy proxy, and RBF-MMD between aggregated posterior means and a standard normal sample for posterior geometry; sample-test MMD, sample pixel variance, and nearest-neighbor distance for generation; and reconstruction BCE after Gaussian input noise or random pixel dropout for robustness. Non-finite training is recorded as `eval_stable=0` and excluded from best-beta selection.

4 Results

4.1 Main result: structured affinity corruption

The central question is not whether Fisher–Rao wins every affinity-matching benchmark. It is whether its bounded geometry helps in the regime where KL’s unbounded pressure is plausibly harmful. To test this directly, we construct a structured affinity-corruption stress test. Starting from clean Gaussian-cluster affinities P_{clean} , we form a training target P_{train} by injecting cross-label probability mass into selected false-neighbor pairs. Both objectives are optimized against P_{train} , but evaluation is performed against the clean data geometry.

Noisy-affinity stress test means across seeds

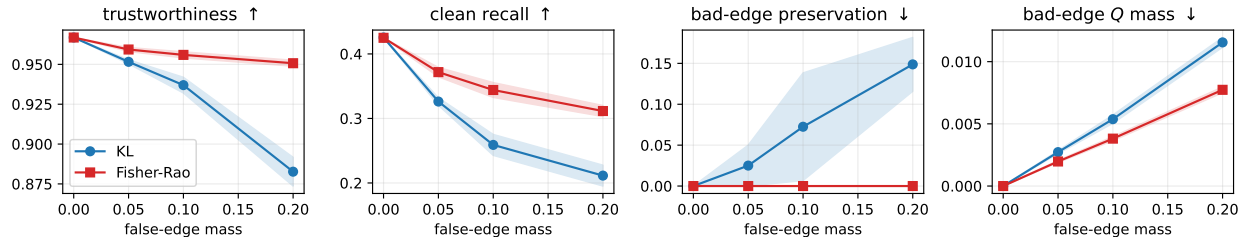


Figure 3: Noisy-affinity stress test under injected false high-probability edges. Unlike feature-noise corruption, this directly contaminates the target pair distribution. KL increasingly preserves the injected bad edges as false-edge mass grows, while Fisher–Rao maintains higher clean-neighborhood metrics and assigns less embedding probability to the corrupted pairs.

Table 1: Noisy-affinity paired differences, Fisher–Rao minus KL, across five seeds. Positive values are better for trustworthiness, recall, silhouette, and local purity; negative values are better for corrupted-edge preservation and corrupted-edge Q mass. With five seeds, Wilcoxon tests are underpowered, so these rows should be read as effect-size evidence for a larger confirmatory run.

False mass	Trust.	Recall	Silh.	Purity	Bad-edge preserved	Bad-edge Q mass
0.05	+0.0077	+0.0456	+0.1171	+0.0115	−0.0250	−0.00075
0.10	+0.0190	+0.0851	+0.1876	+0.0360	−0.0725	−0.00157
0.20	+0.0680	+0.1001	+0.3754	+0.1986	−0.1488	−0.00381

Figure 3 shows the clearest positive result in the study. At false-edge mass 0.2, Fisher–Rao improves trustworthiness by +0.068 and clean-neighborhood recall by +0.100, while reducing corrupted-edge preservation by −0.149 and corrupted-edge Q mass by −0.0038. This is the mechanism predicted by the bounded simplex geometry: KL treats every injected high- P_{ij} edge as an obligation to make Q_{ij} large, whereas Fisher–Rao’s penalty saturates once the square-root distributions are far apart.

We also ran three additional stress families: bridge outliers, continuous manifolds, and parallel-manifold false bridges. Figure 5 summarizes the most diagnostic metric from each family. The outlier-influence experiment does not support a Fisher–Rao advantage; the global-geometry and symmetric-mismatch tests are mixed. The actionable signal is therefore narrow rather than universal: Fisher–Rao appears useful when the *affinity target itself* is contaminated by sparse false-neighbor probability mass.

4.2 Boundary condition: clean-target and feature-noise benchmarks

The positive result above does not imply that Fisher–Rao is a better default t-SNE objective. When the target affinity distribution is clean, or when corruption is applied to input features before constructing P , KL’s asymmetric pressure remains valuable.

Figure 6 shows mean ± 1 standard deviation across 10 seeds for each metric, dataset, and noise level. Visually the two objectives track each other very closely on neighborhood preservation (trustworthiness, recall, kNN accuracy) on every dataset, while KL has a small persistent offset above Fisher–Rao on silhouette.

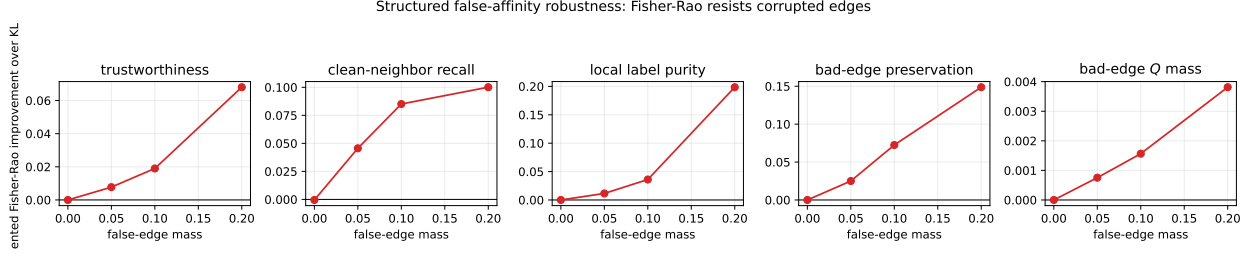


Figure 4: Oriented Fisher–Rao improvement over KL in the noisy-affinity stress test. The last two panels multiply lower-is-better metrics by -1 , so positive values consistently indicate a Fisher–Rao advantage.

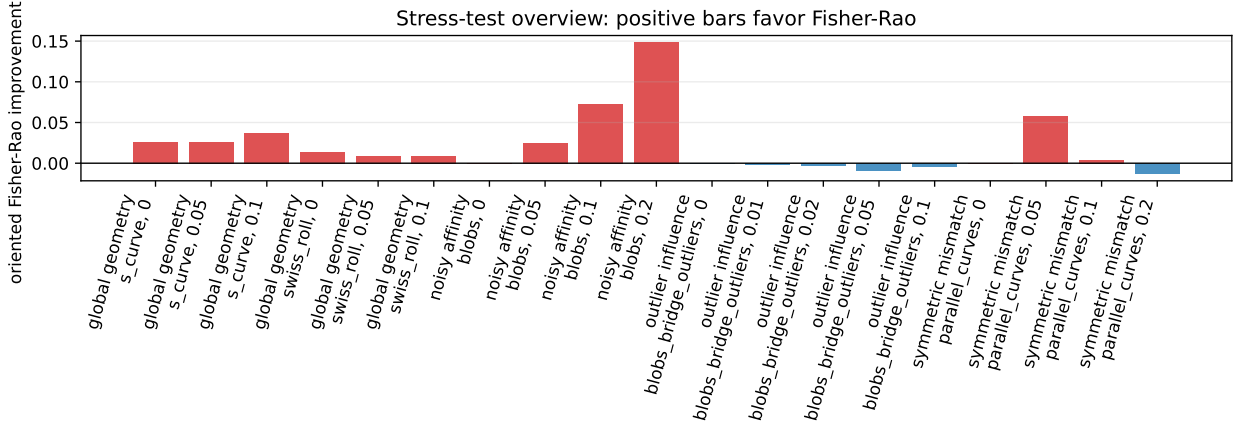


Figure 5: Stress-test overview. Each bar is oriented so positive means Fisher–Rao improves the most diagnostic metric for that stress family. The clearest signal is the noisy-affinity false-edge benchmark; other stress families are weaker or mixed.

4.3 Statistical significance

Table 2 reports the paired Wilcoxon signed-rank test and Cliff’s delta for each (dataset, noise) cell and each metric. Cells where the two objectives differ at $p < 0.05$ are marked with $*$.

The pattern is clean. Out of the 60 cells in Table 2,

- 13 have $p < 0.05$, and *all* 13 *favor* KL;
- 44 are statistically indistinguishable;
- the 13 KL-significant cells are concentrated on (i) silhouette, where KL wins on every dataset at multiple noise levels, and (ii) the simple Gaussian-blobs setting under strong corruption ($\alpha \in \{0.75, 1.0\}$);
- no cell shows a statistically significant Fisher–Rao advantage at the 0.05 level.

4.4 Per-metric average paired improvement

A complementary view averages the paired difference over noise levels for each (dataset, metric) pair (Figure 7). The picture is consistent with Table 2: silhouette is always negative, neighborhood

Final t-SNE embedding quality vs feature noise (mean $\pm$ std over seeds)

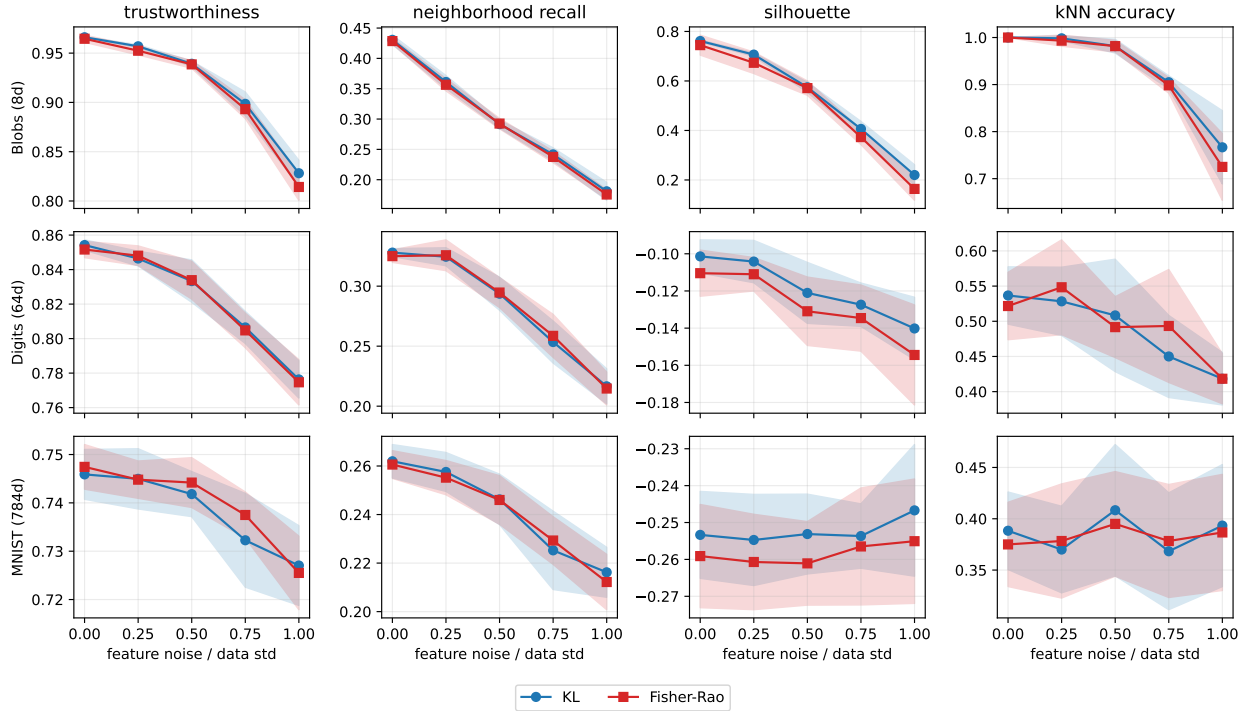


Figure 6: Final t-SNE embedding quality versus feature noise across three datasets, four evaluation metrics, two objectives, and ten seeds. Lines are seed means and shaded bands are ± 1 standard deviation. KL and Fisher-Rao track each other closely on neighborhood preservation but KL has a small consistent advantage on silhouette.

preservation is near-zero with small dataset-dependent fluctuations, and the most favorable Fisher-Rao deviations are on `digits` and MNIST kNN accuracy at intermediate noise levels but do not survive the per-cell significance test.

4.5 Aggregated mean $\pm$ standard deviation

Table 3 reports per-cell mean and standard deviation values used in Figure 6, for the four metrics aggregated to a single number per metric per cell. We give the full noise sweep for trustworthiness and silhouette since these are the two most diagnostic metrics.

4.6 Qualitative embeddings

Figure 8 shows the actual KL and Fisher-Rao embeddings on the `digits` dataset at three noise levels, with shared optimization seed and shared initialization. Cluster geometry is visually similar between objectives at every noise level; the silhouette gap captured in Tables 2–3 is small enough that it is not always obvious from the scatter plots.

Table 2: Paired Wilcoxon signed-rank test of (Fisher–Rao – KL) across 10 seeds. Each cell shows the mean paired difference $\bar{\Delta}$ and Cliff’s delta δ (in brackets). * indicates $p < 0.05$. Negative $\bar{\Delta}$ means KL is better.

Dataset	Noise	Trust. ($\bar{\Delta}$ [δ])	Recall ($\bar{\Delta}$ [δ])	Silh. ($\bar{\Delta}$ [δ])	kNN ($\bar{\Delta}$ [δ])
Blobs	0.00	−0.002 [−0.06]	−0.002 [−0.54]	−0.017 [−0.22]	0.000 [0.00]
	0.25	−0.005 [−0.70]	−0.005 [−0.26]	−0.033 [−0.54]*	−0.005 [−0.21]
	0.50	−0.001 [0.10]	0.001 [0.07]	−0.003 [0.02]	−0.000 [0.01]
	0.75	−0.005 [−0.38]*	−0.004 [−0.15]	−0.033 [−0.54]*	−0.007 [−0.23]
	1.00	−0.014 [−0.58]*	−0.005 [−0.32]	−0.056 [−0.72]*	−0.042 [−0.31]*
Digits	0.00	−0.003 [−0.26]	−0.003 [−0.37]	−0.009 [−0.40]*	−0.015 [−0.28]
	0.25	0.002 [0.18]	0.001 [−0.10]	−0.007 [−0.40]*	0.020 [0.19]
	0.50	0.001 [0.00]	0.001 [−0.06]	−0.010 [−0.36]*	−0.017 [−0.06]
	0.75	−0.002 [−0.06]	0.005 [0.12]	−0.007 [−0.26]	0.043 [0.33]
	1.00	−0.002 [−0.08]	−0.002 [−0.10]	−0.014 [−0.42]*	0.000 [−0.01]
MNIST	0.00	0.002 [0.20]	−0.001 [−0.10]	−0.006 [−0.24]	−0.013 [−0.30]
	0.25	−0.000 [−0.14]	−0.002 [−0.17]	−0.006 [−0.30]	0.008 [0.06]
	0.50	0.002 [0.24]	−0.000 [−0.09]	−0.008 [−0.36]	−0.013 [−0.12]
	0.75	0.005 [0.36]	0.004 [0.13]	−0.003 [−0.24]	0.010 [0.08]
	1.00	−0.002 [−0.02]	−0.004 [−0.24]	−0.008 [−0.40]*	−0.007 [−0.05]

4.7 Optimization dynamics

Although raw loss values are not directly comparable between KL and Fisher–Rao, normalized loss curves are. Figure 9 shows the normalized objective curves on **digits** at the moderate noise level, averaged across seeds. Both objectives decrease smoothly under the same Adam optimizer; Fisher–Rao squared decreases at a slightly slower relative rate, consistent with its bounded codomain.

5 Secondary VAE Check

We also tested whether the same replacement is immediately useful for compact diagonal-Gaussian VAEs. The answer is mostly negative. After independent beta selection on MNIST and Fashion-MNIST, Fisher–Rao is competitive but does not reliably improve reconstruction, latent classification, posterior matching, generation, or corruption robustness. The best-beta paired summary is reported in Appendix A; we keep it out of the main results because the positive contribution of this paper is the categorical affinity-corruption regime, not diagonal-Gaussian VAE regularization.

This secondary result is still useful as a boundary condition. Fisher–Rao’s bounded-codomain argument is specific to categorical simplex geometry; Gaussian Fisher–Rao is unbounded and changes the mean/variance trade-off rather than providing the same robustness mechanism.

6 Discussion

Why does KL win on cluster separation? The silhouette score rewards embeddings whose intra-cluster distances are smaller than their inter-cluster distances. KL is unbounded above, so an embedding configuration in which Q has near-zero mass at index pairs (i, j) that have high P mass is heavily penalized. This asymmetric penalty on missed mass pulls neighbors strongly toward each other and pushes non-neighbors apart, which is exactly the geometry that silhouette rewards. Fisher–Rao squared, in contrast, is capped at π^2 , so the penalty for misallocating mass cannot exceed this bound. The geometric advantage of bounded codomain becomes a practical disadvantage when the goal is aggressive cluster separation, because the objective stops responding once the geodesic angle reaches π .

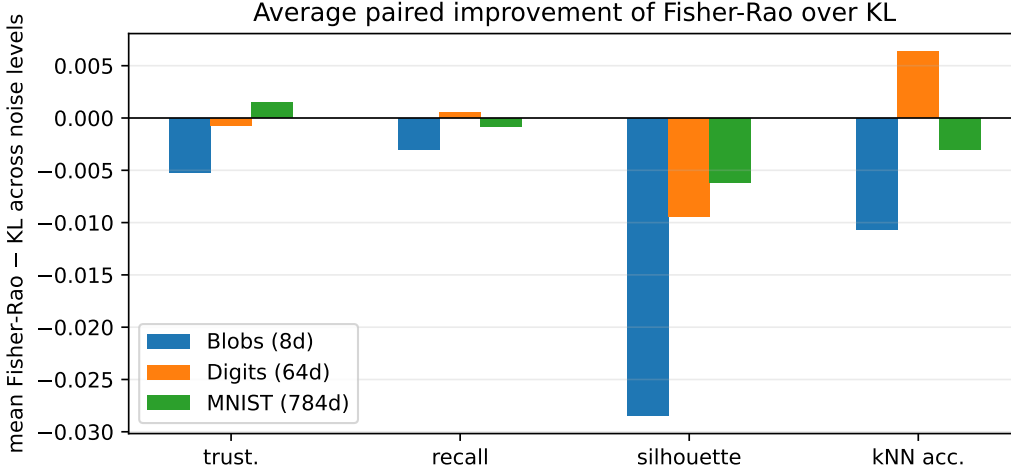


Figure 7: Average paired improvement of Fisher–Rao over KL for each metric, averaged across noise levels, broken down by dataset. Bars below zero mean KL is better on average.

Why are neighborhood metrics indistinguishable? KL and Fisher–Rao squared agree to leading order at $p = q$; they only differ globally. During optimization, especially in the late phase, Q approaches P for the high-probability pair indices, and the two objectives produce similar gradients there. The neighborhood metrics (trustworthiness, recall, kNN accuracy) measure agreement on these high-probability pairs, so they are close to insensitive to the global tail behavior that distinguishes the two objectives.

Why does KL especially dominate on Gaussian blobs at high noise? On well-separated isotropic clusters with strong noise, the clean affinity matrix P has a sparse block-diagonal structure: high mass within clusters, near-zero mass between clusters. Recovering this structure from a noisy $\tilde{X}$ requires the objective to push between-cluster Q_{ij} aggressively toward zero. KL’s unbounded penalty on missed-mass deviations does this naturally; Fisher–Rao’s bounded penalty does not push as hard. In high-dimensional, less cleanly clustered settings (digits, MNIST), there is less sharp block structure to recover, so this advantage attenuates.

When does boundedness help? The structured affinity-corruption experiment in Section 4.1 flips the sign of the story. There, the problem is not that the objective must recover a sharp clean block structure from noisy features; it is that the target distribution itself contains false high-probability edges. KL’s unbounded pressure then becomes a liability because it faithfully pulls those false pairs together. Fisher–Rao is less obedient to extreme target mass and therefore better preserves the clean neighborhoods. This does not rescue Fisher–Rao as a default t-SNE objective, but it identifies a concrete use case: robust affinity matching when the affinity graph is contaminated by spurious high-confidence edges.

Why not center the VAE result? The VAE study tests a different geometry. For Gaussian posteriors, Fisher–Rao is not bounded, so it does not provide the same robustness mechanism that explains the false-neighbor affinity result. In the compact fully connected VAE benchmark, Fisher–Rao is competitive after beta tuning but does not reliably improve downstream metrics. We therefore treat VAEs as a secondary boundary condition rather than the main empirical claim.

Table 3: Mean and standard deviation across 10 seeds for trustworthiness and silhouette, by dataset, noise level, and objective.

Dataset	Noise	Trustworthiness $\uparrow$		Silhouette $\uparrow$	
		KL	Fisher-Rao	KL	Fisher-Rao
Blobs	0.00	0.966 ± 0.000	0.965 ± 0.004	0.761 ± 0.003	0.745 ± 0.040
	0.25	0.957 ± 0.002	0.952 ± 0.004	0.706 ± 0.007	0.673 ± 0.043
	0.50	0.939 ± 0.003	0.939 ± 0.004	0.574 ± 0.020	0.571 ± 0.029
	0.75	0.899 ± 0.012	0.893 ± 0.009	0.406 ± 0.030	0.373 ± 0.030
	1.00	0.828 ± 0.013	0.814 ± 0.013	0.220 ± 0.041	0.164 ± 0.046
Digits	0.00	0.854 ± 0.003	0.852 ± 0.005	-0.101 ± 0.009	-0.110 ± 0.012
	0.25	0.846 ± 0.004	0.848 ± 0.006	-0.104 ± 0.011	-0.111 ± 0.009
	0.50	0.833 ± 0.012	0.834 ± 0.011	-0.121 ± 0.016	-0.131 ± 0.018
	0.75	0.806 ± 0.009	0.805 ± 0.010	-0.127 ± 0.012	-0.135 ± 0.018
	1.00	0.776 ± 0.011	0.775 ± 0.013	-0.140 ± 0.017	-0.154 ± 0.027
MNIST	0.00	0.746 ± 0.005	0.747 ± 0.005	-0.253 ± 0.012	-0.259 ± 0.014
	0.25	0.745 ± 0.006	0.745 ± 0.004	-0.255 ± 0.012	-0.261 ± 0.013
	0.50	0.742 ± 0.005	0.744 ± 0.005	-0.253 ± 0.011	-0.261 ± 0.011
	0.75	0.732 ± 0.010	0.737 ± 0.005	-0.254 ± 0.009	-0.256 ± 0.016
	1.00	0.727 ± 0.008	0.726 ± 0.008	-0.247 ± 0.018	-0.255 ± 0.017

Methodological takeaway. The wider methodological point is that information-geometric replacements for KL should be evaluated where their geometry predicts an advantage, and then checked against clean baselines where KL may remain superior. A single broad “KL replacement” question hides the conditional effect: Fisher-Rao helps when boundedness prevents overfitting corrupted affinity mass, but the same boundedness can hurt cluster separation under clean targets.

7 Limitations

The compact 200-point t-SNE size means the affinity matrix is 200×200 , well below practical t-SNE deployments at 10^4 – 10^5 points. Although nothing in the gradient code prevents scaling, the empirical patterns may shift for larger neighborhoods. We use a fixed median-distance bandwidth instead of perplexity-tuned bandwidths; this matches the simple synthetic baseline but is not the canonical t-SNE preprocessing. The robustness corruption is isotropic Gaussian noise; structured corruption (occlusions, label noise, manifold warping) might give a different ordering. The structured affinity-corruption stress test is currently a pilot with five seeds; its effect sizes motivate a larger confirmation study with more seeds, datasets, and corruption mechanisms such as hub, block, and boundary false edges. Finally, we do not study early-exaggeration or annealing schedules, both of which interact non-trivially with objective scale. Each of these limitations defines a clean follow-up experiment in the same multi-seed framework.

8 Conclusion

Fisher-Rao geometry is useful in a specific regime: robust categorical affinity matching when the target distribution contains false high-confidence neighbors. In that setting, KL’s unbounded pressure faithfully pulls corrupted pairs together, while Fisher-Rao’s bounded simplex geometry reduces overfitting to the bad edges and better preserves clean neighborhoods. This is the positive result of the study.

The same experiments also define the boundary of the claim. Under clean targets and ordinary feature-noise corruption, KL remains the better default for t-SNE-style objectives, especially when

t-SNE embeddings of digits dataset under increasing feature noise (single seed)

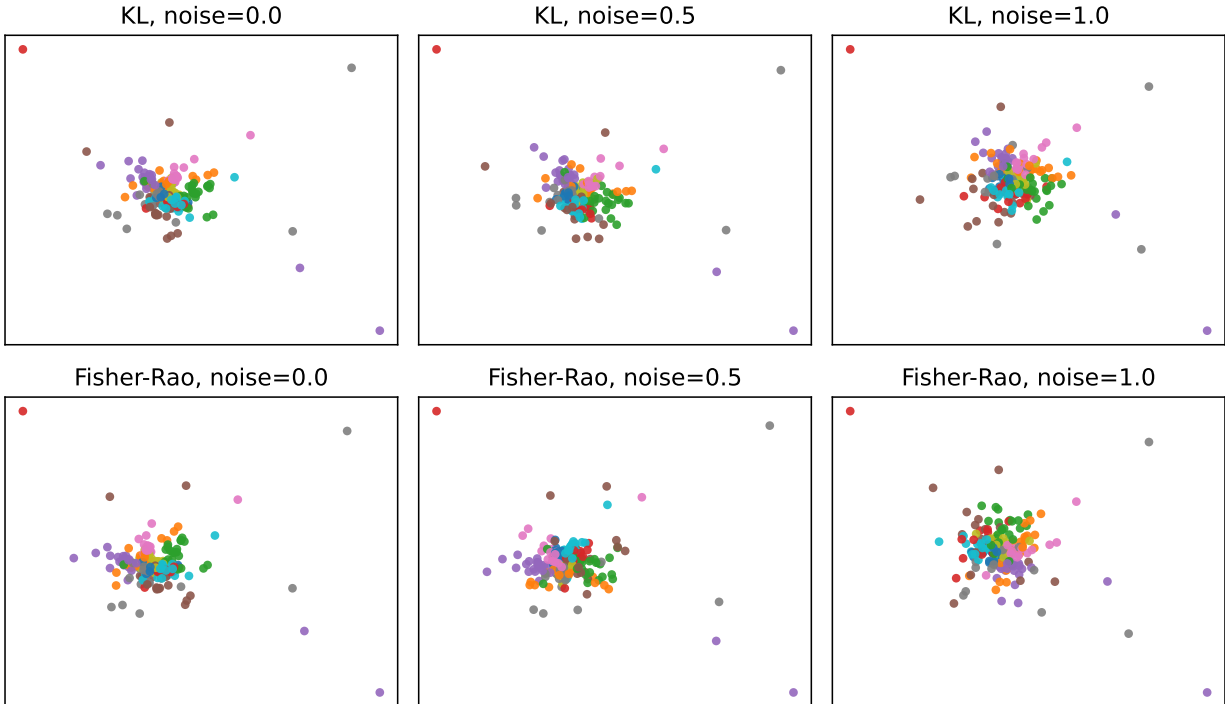


Figure 8: Qualitative t-SNE embeddings of `digits` (single seed) under three feature noise levels for the two objectives. The same initialization and optimizer are used; the two objectives produce visually similar embeddings.

cluster separation is the desired behavior. In compact diagonal-Gaussian VAEs, Fisher-Rao is competitive after beta tuning but does not yield a reliable quality or robustness improvement. The practical recommendation is therefore conditional rather than universal: use Fisher-Rao when robustness to contaminated affinity graphs matters; keep KL when the target distribution is trusted and aggressive neighbor matching is desired.

A VAE Benchmark Details

The VAE benchmark is implemented in the dedicated VAE benchmark script and aggregated by the matching VAE aggregation script. It writes raw per-configuration metrics, mean/std beta summaries, selected best-beta rows, and paired tests under `reports/results`. The benchmark is resumable: completed (dataset, seed, regularizer, β) cells are skipped unless `--force` is passed.

Table 4: Best-beta VAE paired differences, Fisher-Rao minus KL. Positive BCE means Fisher-Rao reconstructs worse; positive latent kNN means Fisher-Rao has better latent classification.

Dataset	BCE/pix	Latent kNN	Posterior MMD	Noise BCE
MNIST	+0.0018	−0.0016	+0.0327	+0.0042
Fashion-MNIST	+0.0025	+0.0133	−0.0002	+0.0026

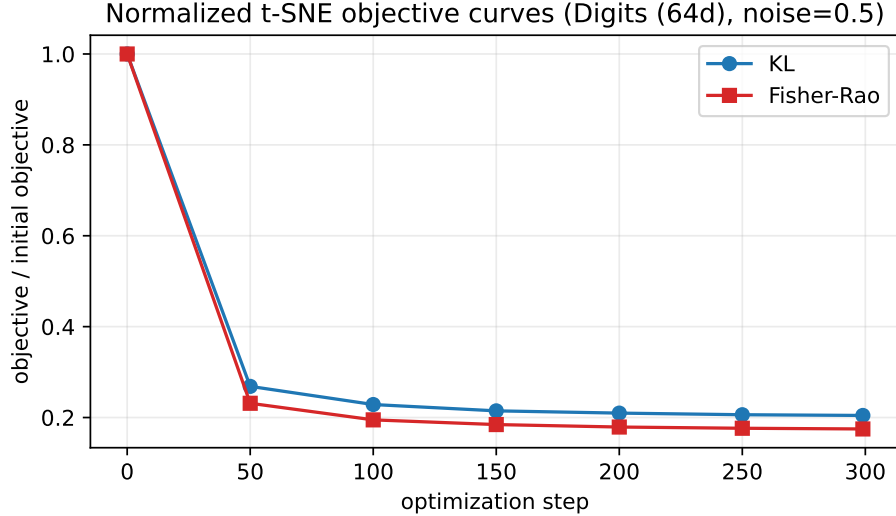


Figure 9: Normalized t-SNE objective curves on `digits` at noise $\alpha = 0.5$. Both objectives are well-behaved under Adam; the relative decrease rates differ because the underlying loss landscapes have different scales.

The table reports mean paired deltas across five seeds after beta selection. None of the listed effects reaches $p < 0.05$ in the two-sided Wilcoxon signed-rank test, so the evidence does not support a claim that Fisher–Rao improves the VAE objective in this setting.

B Dataset and Corruption Details

B.1 Blobs

Generated with `sklearn.datasets.make_blobs(n_samples=200, n_features=8, centers=5, cluster_std=1.6, random_state=0)`, then z-scored. Five Gaussian centers in $\mathbb{R}^8$.

B.2 Digits

A 200-point random subsample (numpy default RNG seeded 0) from sklearn’s `load_digits` bundle, which contains 1797 images of 8×8 pixel handwritten digits, 10 classes, and 64 raw features. Z-scored to zero mean and unit variance.

B.3 MNIST

A 200-point random subsample (numpy default RNG seeded 0) from the MNIST training split, each image flattened to 784 raw pixel features and z-scored.

B.4 VAE datasets

The VAE benchmark uses torchvision MNIST and Fashion-MNIST with raw pixel intensities in $[0, 1]$. For each seed, 1024 training images and 512 test images are sampled without replacement. KMNIST support is implemented in the benchmark script, but the KMNIST download timed out during this run and is therefore not included in the reported VAE tables.

B.5 Robustness corruption

For each noise level $\alpha \in \{0.0, 0.25, 0.5, 0.75, 1.0\}$ and each seed $s \in \{101, 202, \dots, 1010\}$, we draw a fresh standard normal noise tensor of the same shape as the standardized feature matrix and form $\tilde{X} = X + \alpha \epsilon$. The seed for the noise tensor is $1000s + \lfloor 1000\alpha \rfloor$ to keep noise shocks reproducible and distinct across cells.

C Training Dynamics Details

All t-SNE benchmark runs use Adam at learning rate 0.05 for 300 steps, with gradient descent on the 200×2 embedding matrix. Optimizer state is reset for each (dataset, noise, seed, objective) run. The high-dimensional bandwidth is set per dataset to $\sigma = \text{median}_{i < j} \|x_i - x_j\| / \sqrt{2}$ on the clean standardized data, giving $\sigma \approx 2.81$ for blobs, $\sigma \approx 7.0$ for digits, and $\sigma \approx 21.8$ for MNIST.

The full benchmark, including aggregation and statistical analysis, runs in approximately two and a half minutes on Apple Silicon MPS using the script `experiments/paper_benchmark.py` followed by `experiments/aggregate_results.py`, with figures regenerated by `reports/generate_figures.py`. End-to-end the paper can be rebuilt with `make paper-all`.

The VAE benchmark uses `experiments/vae_benchmark.py`. The full default CLI supports ten seeds and ten epochs; the reported local run used five seeds and two epochs to keep the experiment interactive on Apple Silicon while still providing paired beta-tuned comparisons. The command is recorded in the repository history and all output CSVs are stored under `reports/results`.

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